
Harmanpreet Singh



P.R. Sreejesh

revive the average sports fan's relationship with the national sport. For those who have followed the story, the result wasn't a flash in the pan but a milestone years in the making. A new patron helped—the Odisha government began taking an active role in supporting the sport. More investment in grassroots development, stadiums with the latest facilities, more international competitions hosted and the inclusion of scientific and technical support like video analysis—all of it helped the sport grow. A member of Team India for 22 years now, Sreejesh has seen that evolution up close. "The equipment changed, rules changed, venues and audiences changed, how fast the game is played changed," he says.

At the Sports Authority of India's facility in Bengaluru, the team's base camp before they left for Europe in early July for a team-bonding activity in Switzerland and then for a training camp in the Netherlands, the mood was upbeat, the competition healthy and the training intense. "*Khana kha ke* bed *hi dikhta hai* (We only see the bed after a meal)," says Harmanpreet. "*Harek player ek doosre ko push kar raha hai* (We all are pushing each other), be it conditioning, recovery, in gym... Everyone is taking an initiative. Even if we are tired, we know that once we have a medal, all this pain will be accounted for." Sreejesh revealed that he was saving Harmanpreet's much-feared drag flicks, which was boosting his confidence, while the captain spoke about how he was getting a few past the two-time FIH Goalkeeper of the Year. The decorated duo often carries the weight of expectations. Says Harmanpreet, "There's so much trust and belief invested in you, you have to set an example both on and off the field and improve on a day-to-day basis."

For Paris, coach Craig Fulton has assembled a squad where players are expected to be flexible enough to cover two positions when needed. It means the experienced Manpreet Singh, a centre-half in midfield traditionally, serves in defence; Harmanpreet defends and is the central drag-flicker, and vice-captain Hardik Singh, also FIH Men's Player of the Year in 2023, can be seen in all positions barring goalkeeper. Competing in his fourth Olympics, Sreejesh is the lynchpin, the opposing team's worst nightmare come true. His ability to hold his position for two decades is noteworthy. "If a goalkeeper makes one mistake, it is visible. Win or lose is in his hands and feet," notes Sreejesh. "I always try to become better than yesterday. I take responsibility for my team. I always feel that because of my mistake, my team and the country shouldn't suffer." He hasn't given much to complain about in the past few years.

"THERE IS PRESSURE TO DO WELL AND COME BACK WITH A MEDAL. YOU WANT TO DO BETTER. YOU HAVE TO KEEP ACHIEVING"

— HARMANPREET SINGH
Captain, Men's Hockey Team

After the Men in Blue ended a 13-year drought for an ICC World Cup trophy, a viral message touched on the coincidence of how each World Cup win featured a "Mallu" in the squad; Sanju Samson, in this case. Sreejesh, the lone "Mallu" for four editions now, saw the message, and the nail-biting final too. "We always try to learn from other sports. It taught us that one over, one moment [is enough], we snatched the victory from them," he says. The Men in Blue at the Olympics will be hoping for a like moment. ■

–Suhani Singh